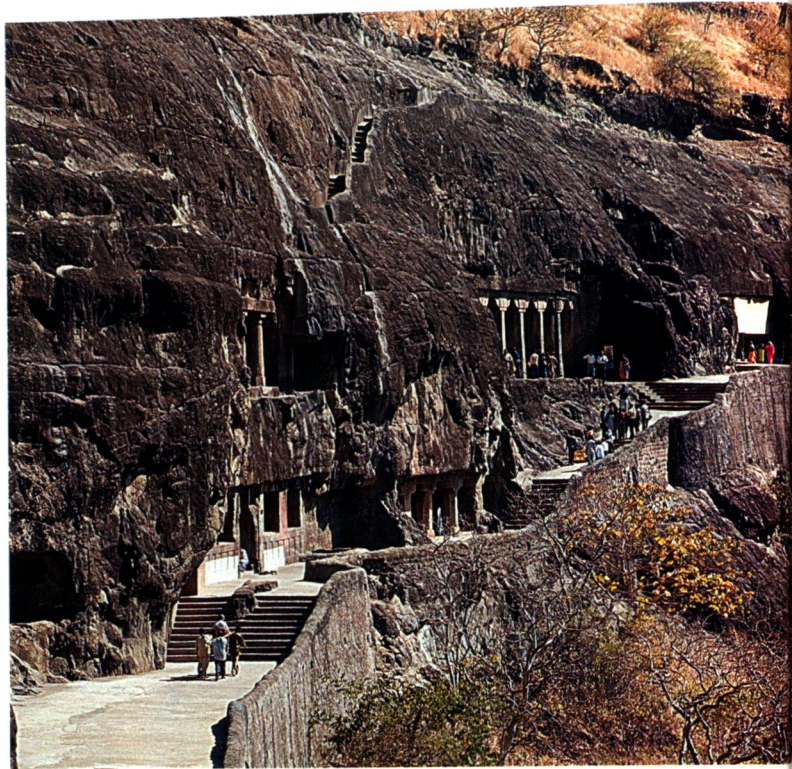


■ By Kaveree Bamzai and Renu Ojha

It's a war between one of the world's leading authorities on the Ajanta caves and the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) and it threatens to call into question almost all conservation work the organisation has done on the world heritage site. What sparked off a controversy was ASI's plan to rebuild the portico in Cave 1. Though ASI says the plan was only at an inception stage, it has run into trouble with Walter M. Spink, a venerable 79-year-old Professor (Emeritus) of Indian Art at the University of Michigan, who first studied the second century rock-cut Ajanta caves, about 100 km from Aurangabad, Maharashtra, in 1952.

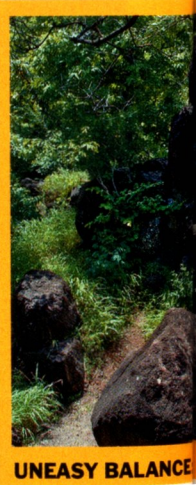
The fight is over the issue of approach. One is that of leaving the site as it is and the other is what Spink contemptuously calls "prettification". Prettification, which he insists ASI has been following, has meant the following: ASI has rebuilt pillars in Cave 21, reconstructed fallen rocks in Cave 14 and in Cave 19, reconstructed a cell to protect a sculptural panel. It has done all of this using cement. In 1998, Spink had halted almost similar efforts by ASI to clean the murals. The current impasse has troubled UNESCO enough to consider sending a fact-finding mission to Ajanta, which was given world heritage status in 1983, India's first along with the Taj Mahal. Nicole Bolomey, UNESCO Programme Specialist, Culture, insists that modern conservation philosophies are critical towards the use of cement. "Repairs in cement are not reversible and as it is harder than stone, it leads to faster weathering of the original material," she says.

Even the Geological Survey of India (GSI), whose data ASI is quoting to bolster its claim of boulder instability, seems perturbed. As Manohar Sinha, director, GSI, puts it: "ASI's approach is usually very casual and they don't foresee the implications of their actions. About a year ago, they sealed a rock void without consulting us. They are known to carry out structural changes without our knowledge. We are planning to approach a competent authority with our concerns." Even the panel of experts, which is part of the Ajanta-Ellora conservation and



CAVEMAN TACTICS

Thirty loose boulders. Cracks in caves. Unstable slopes. The world heritage site at Ajanta suffers from many problems but the greatest threat may well be from ASI's dated conservation efforts.



UNEASY BALANCE

tourism development project funded by Japan Bank of International Cooperation (JBIC), in the minutes of a meeting held in 2004, noted that "the matter of using cement came in for serious adverse comments". It added that ASI must initiate talks with professionals as also experts on alternative techniques and that "proper research and documentation shall be manda-

tory regarding any intervention".

The conservation is not limited by lack of finance. The Ajanta-Ellora project, the result of an agreement between Overseas Economic Cooperation Fund, Japan, and the President of India, signed in 1992, is flush with funds of Rs 81 crore. ASI, in its defence, refers to practices first used in the 1960s but UNESCO experts say conservation, in its